started, nap when he napped. (In 1968, John Wheeler, Andrei Sakharov, and I spent an afternoon discussing physics with him in a hotel room in the deep south of the Soviet Union. After several hours of intense discussion, Zel'dovich abruptly announced that it was time to nap. He then laid down and slept for twenty minutes, while Wheeler, Sakharov, and I relaxed and read quietly in our respective corners of the room, waiting for him to awaken.)

Impatient with perfectionists like me, who insist on getting all the details of a calculation right, Zel'dovich cared only about the main concepts. Like Oppenheimer, he could scatter irrelevant details to the winds and zero in, almost unerringly, on the central issues. A few arrows and curves on the blackboard, an equation not longer than half a line, a few sentences of vivid prose, with these he would bring his team to the heart of a research problem.

He was quick to judge an idea or a physicist's worth, and slow to change his judgments. He could retain faith in a wrong snap judgment for years, thereby blinding himself to an important truth, as when he rejected the idea that tiny black holes can evaporate (Chapter 12). But when (as was usually the case) his snap judgments were right, they enabled him to move forward across the frontiers of knowledge at a tremendous pace, faster than anyone I have ever met.

The contrast between Zel'dovich and Wheeler was stark: Zel'dovich whipped his team into shape with a firm hand, a constant barrage of his own ideas, and joint exploitation of his team's ideas. Wheeler offered his fledglings a philosophical ambience, a sense that there were exciting ideas all around, ready for the plucking; but he rarely pressed an idea, in concrete form, onto a student, and he absolutely never joined his students in exploiting their ideas. Wheeler's paramount goal was the education of his fledglings, even if that slowed the pace of discovery. Zel'dovich—still infused with the spirit of the race for the superbomb—sought the fastest pace possible, whatever the expense.

Zel'dovich was on the telephone at ungodly hours of the morning, demanding attention, demanding interaction, demanding progress. Wheeler seemed to us, his fledglings, the busiest man in the world; far too busy with his own projects to demand our attention. Yet he was always available at our request, to give advice, wisdom, encouragement.